Sridevi



MANDAR DEODHAR

No other actress can claim to having occupied the No. 1 position across four language cinemas simultaneously: Hindi, Telugu, Tamil and Kannada. Her incredible comedic range (*Mr India*, 1987; *Chaalbaaz*, 1989) is a trope in itself, but you only had to watch *Chandni* (1989), *Lamhe* (1991) or *English Vinglish* (2012) to know she could steal scenes with the tiniest nuances. Cinephiles swear by Kamal Haasan's heart-breaking performance in the climax of *Sadma* (1983), but it's Sridevi, as Reshmi, recently recovered from amnesia, who owns the scene with the puzzled, pitiful look she casts his way, their relationship and his identity now a lost memory. Pure gold.



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Tabu

The poster girl for minimalism in an industry whose SOP is heightened drama, Tabu is that rare contemporary actress who ticks both options in virtually every multiple choice question. Mainstream or Arthouse? Both. Drama or Comedy? Both. Hindi or Regional? Both. Bollywood or International? Both. Is there anything she cannot do?

Blessed with eyes that suggest depth and wisdom beyond her years, Tabu became the muse for some of the sharpest filmmakers at their creative peak: Gulzar (*Maachis*, 1996), Vishal Bhardwaj (*Maqbool*, 2004; *Haider*, 2014), Priyadarshan (*Kaalapani*, 1996; *Virasat*, 1997), Mira Nair (*The Namesake*, 2006), Sriram Raghavan (*Andhadhun*, 2018). And yet, is there another actress equally at home delivering laughs in decidedly escapist fare like *Golmaal Again* (2017)?

Vidya Balan

Vidya Balan is Everywoman. *Tumhari Sulu* (2017), *Kahaani* (2012), *No One Killed Jessica* (2011), *Jalsa* (2022)—in each of these films, she's a wholly identifiable person. Someone you could see in your world and relate to, conveying her inner struggles with so little: subtle body language, little realistic nuances, a conversational lilt. But just as easily, Balan separated each of these roles through her craft—you just couldn't confuse Sabrina with Sulochana. There's a joy in watching Vidya Balan because she invests herself in her characters; whether based on real people like Silk Smitha (*The Dirty Picture*, 2011) or fictional, like the lion-hearted mother of a 13-year-old Amitabh Bachchan in *Paa* (2009). An inordinate willingness to take risks gilds that.



RAJWANT RAWAT